NANA'S
Leo Book

A STORYBOOK TO KEEP & SHARE



A KEEPSAKE STORYBOOK

NANA'S LEO BOOK

RAMBLEBOOK

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ABOUT THIS DRAFT

Nana's Leo Book is a working draft, produced with RambleBook from an original story idea. It is complete as a story — beginning, middle, and end, in 6 chapters — and deliberately unfinished as a book. Chapter One is written at full weight; the chapters that follow are leaner, the way first drafts are: the bones and the heartbeat, waiting for a writer's second pass. Writing is rewriting. This is the draft you rewrite from.

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Chapter 1

The Cardboard Rocket

In Nana's garden, behind the tomato plants and the rose bush that scratched anybody who got fresh with it, there stood a rocket.

It was made of cardboard. It was held together with tape, hope, and one of Nana's good bedsheets, which Nana pretended not to recognize. And it belonged, entirely and officially, to Leo — who was 6 years old, and curious, and brave, and giggly all the way through, like the letters in a stick of rock candy.

"Nana!" called Leo, from the top of a step stool, which was Mission Control. "The rocket is ready. The moon is ready. Are YOU ready?"

Nana looked up from the garden. She was holding a wooden spoon, because she had been stirring something, but Leo knew the truth about that spoon. Everybody in the family knew. It was not really a spoon.

It was a wand that had retired and taken up cooking.

"Ready," said Nana, and she hung the spoon from her belt like a sword. "But a launch takes courage. Do we have courage?"

"We have courage," said Leo. "We have courage, we have snacks, and we have—" Leo reached into the rocket and held up a small, serious passenger. "—we have Biscuit, the very patient dog."

"Then we have everything," said Nana. "Climb aboard, Captain."

Chapter 2

The Night Nana Said Yes

Most grown-ups say, “It’s nearly bedtime.” Most grown-ups say, “Rockets are for tomorrow.”

But Nana remembered something important. She remembered the day — the famous day — when he fed his spaghetti to the dog, one noodle at a time. She had laughed so hard that day that her tea came out of her nose, which Leo still described as “the funniest emergency ever.”

A kid who can cause a tea emergency, Nana figured, can be trusted with the moon.

So as the first stars came out, Nana checked the rocket’s tape. She checked the snacks twice, because snacks are the part of space travel that scientists take most seriously. Then she did the thing she always did before anything big: she pointed her spoon at the sky and whispered the words every

grandma knows and no book has ever printed — until now.

They are very secret. They rhyme with “moon.” That is all you get.

The garden lights flickered. The tomato plants stood up straighter. And the cardboard rocket, very quietly, cleared its throat.

Chapter 3

The Moon Is Made of Mac And Cheese

Here is what the astronauts never tell you: the moon smells wonderful, and that is because the moon is made, almost entirely, of mac and cheese.

Leo took the first step onto the Sea of Tranquility and it went squish in the nicest possible way. “Nana,” Leo whispered, “we have to tell everybody.”

“We tell nobody,” said Nana, already spreading the picnic blanket. “Some things are just for us.”

They ate mac and cheese on the moon, with the whole Earth hanging in the sky like a blue marble somebody loved very much. And Leo did the thing Leo always does, right there on the moon, because a quirk is a quirk and it does not care about gravity: he roars like a dinosaur whenever a door opens.

“Leo,” said Nana, “when you’re very old, you’ll forget some things. Try to remember this picnic.”

“I’ll remember,” said Leo. “I’ll remember because it’s OURS.”

Chapter 4

The Great Space Race

Trouble in space never looks like trouble. Ours looked like a game.

A sleepy little comet — no bigger than a teapot, and twice as lost — came wobbling past the picnic blanket, crying tiny sparks. It had lost the race. It had lost the other comets. It had, in fact, lost everything except speed.

"We have to help," said Leo, "and I know exactly how."

Because Leo knew a game. Not a screen game or a board game — a Leo game, the famous one: dinosaurs vs. robots. And here is the secret about the famous games of 6-year-olds: if you play them at full power, with your whole heart, they work anywhere. Even in orbit. Especially in orbit.

Leo played. Nana played. Biscuit, the very patient dog supervised from the rocket window, looking extremely official.

The little comet laughed so hard it found its sparkle again — and a found sparkle, in space, is the same thing as a found road home.

Chapter 5

Almost Home

Coming home is the hardest part of any adventure. The rocket was tired. The tape was tired. Halfway down through the dark, Leo felt the wobble that every captain dreads, and for one whole second, Leo was scared.

Just one second. Then Leo remembered being curious. Remembered being brave — yes, even that; silly is a kind of engine. And remembered being giggly, which is the strongest one of all, and held the little comet's light steady in both hands until the wobble passed.

Below them, a garden was waking up. One window was lit. And in the window, waving both arms like a lighthouse that had won the lottery, was the person Leo would cross any sky to get back to.

"Nana," said Leo, sleepy as a bear in November, "we made it home before bedtime."

“We made it home,” said Nana, “before the end of bedtime. There’s a difference. Captains know it.”

Chapter 6

Nana's Shelf

The rocket lives in the garden still. The tape is new. The sheet has been washed, ironed, and returned to the linen closet under circumstances nobody discusses.

But the important thing — the thing this whole book was made to tell you — is on a shelf.

If you go to Nana's house, and you look on Nana's very best shelf, between the photographs and the mug that says WORLD'S OKAYEST GARDENER (a title Nana defends fiercely), you will find this book. This one. The one you are holding.

It stays there because Nana shows it to people. She shows it to the neighbors. She shows it to the book club, and the postman, and once to a man who only came to read the meter. And whenever Leo visits, she takes it down, and they read it together,

and the moon is made of mac and cheese all over again.

Some books are for reading.

This one is for keeping.

The End — love, always, Nana

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

RambleBook makes storybooks about the people you love, for the people who keep them.

A storybook to keep & share

Leo is 6 years old — curious, brave, and giggly all the way through. In this story, Leo and Nana fly a cardboard rocket to a moon made of mac and cheese. A keepsake storybook about Leo, made for Nana to keep, to show, and to read aloud.